



Marriage #1



Marriage #2



Marriage #3



Marriage #4



Marriage #5

She married
many times,
but never
stopped loving
the one man.

Her confession
is the truth
she finally
choose.

bad girl gospel

THE STORY OF DIANA

*A confession about love, marriage,
memory, and the man she never
stopped trying to forget.*

Elias
♡

SABINO PEREIRA

Bad Girl Gospel: The Story of Diana

A Confession About Marriage

Sabino Pereira

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Fiction Note

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, relationships, and events are used imaginatively. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, or to real events, is coincidental. This book explores marriage, divorce, emotional harm, spiritual pressure, shame, and healing through a fictional confession.

Author's Note

Bad Girl Gospel was born from a simple question: What happens when a woman the world has already reduced to one word finally gets to tell her own version? For years, I have heard stories about women described as too much. Too sensual. Too cold. Too intense. Too complicated. Too divorced. Too free. Too something. Most of the time, the story came through someone else's mouth.

This book, and this series, is not a courtroom created to clean reputations. It is not a manifesto designed to glorify toxic behaviour with better aesthetics. It is something else. Bad Girl Gospel is an archive of the versions that never reached the court of public opinion. It is a place where the judged woman speaks in the first person, where she can admit what was done to her, what she did to others, and what she keeps doing to herself without being forced to choose between victim and villain. Selah and Diana are not role models.

They are cracked mirrors. In them, you may recognise pieces of yourself, someone you once loved, or someone you once judged too quickly. If at any point you find yourself thinking, "I have been this woman," or "I have treated someone like this," then the confession has already begun its work. The aim was never to create heroines. It was to create honesty.

Bad Girl Gospel, at its core, is a gospel told from the side of misread women. Not to prove they are good. But to show they are more than the stories that were told about them.

Opening Manifesto

A Confession About Marriage

My name is Diana.

People don't say it like a name anymore.
They say it like a file.

"Diana?
The one who married all those times?"
"The woman who can't stay?"
"The one who treats vows like wardrobe changes?"

They know the dresses.
They know the rings.
They know the divorces.

They know how many times I walked down an aisle.
They do not know what I carried to each altar.

For most people, I am a warning.

Don't be like her.
Don't be so unstable.
Don't be so needy.
Don't be so dramatic about love.

They say I love too easily.
They say I run too quickly.
They say I never learned how to honour vows.

That is their version.

Here is mine.

I did not marry many times because I loved too easily.

I married many times because one man never left me.

Elias was the first name my heart called home.

He was not safe.

He was not consistent.

He was not always kind.

But he was first.

And sometimes first feels like truth before you are old enough to know the difference.

He taught me that love had to hurt to be real.

That jealousy meant depth.

That chaos meant passion.

That peace meant boredom.

After Elias, my body did not recognise love unless it came with damage.

After Elias, my heart did not trust calm.

After Elias, silence started to sound like abandonment, even when it was only rest.

Every marriage after him was an attempt at amnesia.

One man gave me security.

One gave me desire.

One gave me stability.

One looked like a future everyone could approve of.

I said yes to all of them with a heart that was never fully in the room.

A piece of me stayed where Elias left me.

I am not proud of this:

I punished some men for wounds they did not give me.

I measured their love by Elias' intensity.

I compared their calm to his storms and called them shallow.

I called their patience "lack of passion."

I called their faithfulness "predictable."

I told myself I was bored.

Maybe I was just unfamiliar with peace.

Marriage became my favourite costume.

I wore it well.

I posted it well.

I performed it well.

If I was married, I could not be the bad girl they talked about.

If I was married, I was respectable again.

If I was married, maybe God would see the ring before He saw the lie.

That is what I told myself.

But a vow cannot heal what a woman refuses to name.

There is a difference between loving covenant and fearing loneliness.

For years, I did not know which one I was doing.

This is not the story of a woman who could not commit.

This is the story of a woman who kept trying to fix her first
heartbreak with new last names.

Elias is not the hero of this book.

He is the ghost.

The ghost in every argument.

The ghost in every bedroom.

The ghost in every comparison I never said out loud.

The ghost that made me think:

"If he does not hurt me, he does not really love me."

I walked into houses that had space for me
and lived in them like a guest.

I cooked.

I cleaned.

I smiled in photos.

I shared bills.

I shared beds.

But I did not always share my heart.

I blamed fear.

I blamed culture.

I blamed our parents' marriages.

I blamed men.

I blamed God.

Some of that blame belonged.

Most of it was incomplete.

There were things no one made me do.

I said yes when my no was louder.
I stayed when I knew I was already gone.
I used "we" to hide from the work of "I."
I broke vows and then hid behind wounds.

I have been the bride,
the ex-wife,
the scandal,
the prayer request,
the punchline.

I am writing this because I am tired of hearing my story only in
other people's mouths.

This is not a defence.

It is an inventory.

Of love that burned.
Of vows that cracked.
Of houses that looked right and felt wrong.
Of men who tried.
Of men who harmed.
Of the one man who never left my memory and almost ruined
my future.

This confession is not about making me look holy.
It is about telling the truth where I used to tell pretty lies.

So this is mine:

Marriage did not fix what was broken in me.
Divorce did not make me unworthy of love.
Elias did not ruin my life.
I did the ruining plenty of times myself.

I do not need another husband to prove I am a good woman.
I do not need to go back to my first love to validate my past.

I need to stop running from the part of me that keeps saying yes
for the wrong reasons.

My name is Diana.

I have worn too many dresses.
I have broken promises.
I have stayed when I should have gone
and gone when I promised to stay.

This is not the story of how I finally became the perfect wife.

This is the story of how I stopped using marriage to avoid
meeting myself.

And if I stay this time,
it will not be at an altar.

It will be in a life where I no longer confuse being chosen with
being whole.

Chapter 1

The Rumor

No one remembered how old Diana was when they first started counting her weddings. They only remembered the number.

“Four, right?” “No, five.” “Didn’t she remarry one of them?” “I lost track after the second.”

People said her name with a raised eyebrow.

“Diana? The one who keeps getting married?” “The one who loves the dress more than the man?” “The one who treats ‘forever’ like a subscription she can cancel?”

They knew the photos. They knew the venues. They knew the surnames she had worn and taken off again. They did not know the vows she whispered under her breath, the ones nobody heard. She’s unstable. She’s dramatic. She can’t live alone. She can’t be trusted with promises. They said it in salons while someone else’s hair was getting done. They said it in church corridors between services. They said it in group chats labelled with praying hands and gossip emojis. They said it in family kitchens when someone mentioned her in a “bless her heart” tone. Men talked about her like a warning.

“Women like that never stay.” “She’ll marry you and leave the moment she gets bored.” “She likes weddings, not marriage.”

Some of them were bitter. Some of them were fascinated. Some of them had once rehearsed a proposal in their head and decided against it because they were afraid of becoming the next number in her story. Women talked about her like a cautionary tale.

“She’s proof you should choose better the first time.” “She’s what happens when you believe in fairy tales after thirty.” “She thinks marriage is therapy but refuses to sit alone with herself.”

They shook their heads. They scrolled her photos. They zoomed in on her dress, her smile, her eyes.

“That’s not happiness,” one would say. “That’s performance.”

They rarely asked how much of their own marriage was performance too. In church, they said her name softer.

“She’s been through a lot.” “We need to pray for her.” “Marriage is sacred; she just... doesn’t seem to understand that.”

They did not say divorced out loud. They said “went through some things.” They did not say “again.” They let the silence count for them. Leaders shook her hand with a particular kind of grip.

Half compassion. Half correction.

“You have to slow down, Diana.” “You need to heal before you commit again.” “You know God hates divorce, right?”

As if she did not know every verse people reach for when they want to make sure a woman feels the full weight of her choices. The rumor was simple. She loved too easily. She promised too quickly. She ruined good men. She ran when things got real. She was the problem. No one sounded entirely sure when they said it.

But they said it anyway. No one told the same story twice. In one version, she was the villain. In another, she was naïve. In another, she was a romantic who never grew up. In another, she was a manipulator who loved attention more than truth. The details changed. The headline stayed the same.

By the time Diana walked into a room, the room had already decided which chapter of her life it believed in. If she wore white, she was acting like a bride again. If she wore black, she was mourning the

latest one. If she wore no ring, it was only a matter of time. If she wore a ring, it was, “Let’s see how long this one lasts.” The story always arrived before she did. It sat at the table. It poured itself coffee. It nodded at people who had not met her and said, “You’ll see.” Diana was not a person in most conversations.

She was a category. The woman who loves the idea of marriage. The woman who can’t keep a man. The woman who doesn’t respect vows. The woman who clearly has issues. Few people asked what those issues were. Issues is a convenient word. It suggests depth without requiring curiosity.

They didn’t know about Elias. Some had heard the name in fragments.

“Wasn’t there one she really loved?” “I think there was someone before the first husband.” “Didn’t he hurt her?” “Didn’t she hurt him?”

The details blurred. Most people preferred the cleaner version: Diana is like this because she is like this. It was easier than believing that one man, one story, one season could echo through a lifetime of decisions. So the rumor walked ahead of her.

Into dates. Into family dinners. Into counselling sessions. Into job interviews. Into new churches where people promised they didn’t judge and then did, quietly, by keeping her in prayer. They didn’t know about the nights she went home alone after the jokes, sat on the edge of a borrowed bed, and wondered if maybe they were right. Maybe she was the common denominator. Maybe she was the danger. Maybe she was the reason love kept collapsing. They didn’t know the way her stomach tightened whenever someone said “forever” around her like it was a simple word.

They didn’t know how her hands shook the first time she signed divorce papers. Or how numb they felt the third time. To them, she was a rumor in a nice dress. To her, she was a woman who kept

standing in front of altars hoping geography would fix what history had broken. But The Rumor had no interest in that part.

The Rumor only cared about the count. How many times she said “I do.” How many times she later said “I can’t.” It was rarely:

“What did she believe about love?” “What did she see growing up?” “What did the first man teach her about staying?”

It was mostly:

“She just doesn’t know how to be a wife.”

If Diana laughed too loud, it was because she didn’t respect marriage. If she sat quietly, it was because she was ashamed. If she posted nothing, she was hiding the next collapse. If she posted everything, she was flaunting her instability. She could not win in a world that had already chosen the caption. She married too many times. Full stop. That was the line people liked to repeat.

They did not see what she was running from. They did not see who she was still walking with, even when he wasn’t in the room. They did not see that every “yes” she gave was also a “maybe” to someone else. They did not see the ghost that sat between her and every man who tried to love her. They did not see Elias. Not yet. For now, the world only knew this:

Diana was the woman who loved marriage too much to stay out of it, and not enough, apparently, to stay in it. And if there is one thing people love almost as much as a wedding, it is a woman to blame when the photos don’t match the ending. That was The Rumor. It wasn’t the whole story. But it was loud enough that even Diana, some nights, started to believe it.

Chapter 2

Before the Rings

Before Diana ever signed her name on a marriage certificate, she had already learned what a wife was supposed to be. Not from books. From rooms. From the way her mother's shoulders changed shape when her father walked in. From the way arguments ended as soon as someone said, "Remember your vows." From whispers in kitchens where women spoke quietly but carried heavy truths.

"Better a husband who comes home late than no husband at all." "Men calm down when they marry." "Sometimes you just need to be patient and pray."

Diana absorbed these sentences the way children absorb weather. They became the climate she grew up in. She learned early that marriage was not just about love. It was about respectability. Stability. Legitimacy. The married woman sat at the table with a different kind of authority.

Even if she was miserable, people lowered their voices when they spoke around her. She had earned titles. Wife. Mother. Respectable. The unmarried woman over a certain age got different titles. Independent. Picky. Too much. Suspicious.

As a girl, Diana watched the way her elders looked at single women. There was always a question hiding behind their eyes.

"What's wrong?"

Too loud? Too quiet? Too ambitious? Too broken? No one said it that crudely. They didn't have to. Diana learned that being chosen was not just romance. It was protection.

From questions. From pity. From the assumption that your life was incomplete. She watched men too. Uncles who shouted but paid the bills. Cousins who cheated but still got celebrated at Christmas. Husbands who disappeared emotionally but never missed a Sunday service. She noticed something. A man could fail at marriage and still be considered a man.

A woman who failed at marriage became a warning.

“Don’t end up like her.”

So when Diana thought about her future, she did not picture a career first, or a city, or a set of keys. She pictured a ring. Not the metal. The meaning.

“You’re safe now.” “You’re chosen.” “You’re not a problem anymore.”

She saw weddings before she understood marriages. Dresses that took up whole doorways. Cakes taller than some of the guests. Photographers who acted like priests, positioning people as if joy depended on the angle. She saw brides shaking, though she did not yet know if it was from fear or excitement. She saw grooms clasping hands a little too tightly, as if they were holding on to a solution, not a person. She overheard the older women again.

“He’s a good man. He’ll calm her down.” “She’s lucky. Not everyone gets a chance like that.” “Marriage will settle her.”

Settle. It sounded like love and discipline in the same word. As a teenager, Diana tried to imagine herself unmarried at thirty. The picture made her chest tighten. Where would she sit at family gatherings? Who would introduce her? How many times would she have to explain herself?

“I’m focusing on my career.” “I just haven’t met the right one.” “I’m happy as I am.”

All of them true for some women. Diana did not yet know what would be true for her. She only knew that she did not want to be the story people told in half sentences.

“She’s still... you know... single.”

So marriage became a destination on her map before she even knew what kind of traveller she was. Her parents did not tell her to rush. They told her to be careful.

“Don’t marry just for a wedding,” her mother said once.

But the way she looked at her own ring betrayed how deeply she believed in its protection. Diana watched the way her mother touched the band when she was anxious, as if the gold could anchor her. She learned that vows were both promise and shield. In church, marriage was preached as a holy thing.

“Two become one.” “What God has joined together...” “Marriage is a picture of Christ and the church.”

Big language. She listened, wide-eyed, to sermons that seemed more interested in warning women not to leave than in warning men not to become unbearable. The message landed crooked. God loves covenant. God hates divorce. No one explained what God thought about manipulation, or contempt, or a woman disappearing inside a life she never really chose.

They just said:

“Pray.” “Stay.” “Honour your vows.”

Diana heard the stories behind the verses. Women who stayed and lost themselves. Women who left and lost their community. Women who never married and lost everyone’s patience. She did not want any of those endings. So she took notes. This is what she learned before the rings:

A good woman gets married. A patient woman keeps the marriage. A holy woman endures. A serious woman does not jump from man to man. A grateful woman does not leave when it gets hard. What no one taught her was this: A wise woman asks herself if she is whole enough to share a life before she promises one. No one taught her how to distinguish between wanting a partner and wanting an identity upgrade. No one taught her the difference between being loved and being absorbed into someone else's story.

They told her marriage was a team. They did not always show her what to do when the life she entered already came with someone else's name, history, and unhealed wounds written into the walls. Diana grew up with a quiet conviction: If I get marriage right, everything else will fall into place. She did not yet know that you can get the ceremony perfect and still walk into a house carrying a broken version of yourself.

Before the rings, she was already rehearsing vows in her head. Not the ones the pastor would say. The ones underneath.

"I will never end up alone." "I will never be the problem." "I will prove I can do this." "I will prove I am worth staying for."

The dangerous thing about silent vows is that no one else knows they are in the room. When Elias arrived, he did not hear all of that. He only heard her laugh, saw her eyes, felt the way she leaned in. He did not know he was walking into a life where marriage was not just a choice. It was a rescue mission she didn't yet realise she had signed him up for.

Before the rings, Diana had already decided that being a wife was the safest way to be a woman. No one had told her yet that safety built on fear will ask for sacrifices love was never supposed to demand.

Chapter 3

Elias

Before Elias, love was theory. Verses. Stories. Movies where people ran in the rain and called that destiny. Then he walked in, and theory found a body. He was not the handsomest man she had ever seen. Not the tallest. Not the safest. But he had that thing.

The kind of presence that made a room feel smaller and larger at the same time. The kind of attention that landed on you like sunlight and interrogation. He did not look at her like she was cute. He looked at her like she was significant. That was dangerous. Diana met him at an age where intensity feels like a calling.

He laughed loudly. Argued passionately. Apologised rarely. He could be kind in ways that made everyone else look lazy. He could be cruel in ways that made everyone else look harmless. He was the first man who made her feel: Seen. Chosen. Terrified.

He asked questions no one had asked her before.

“Do you even know what you want?” “Do you like your life, or are you just managing it?” “Do you believe God for yourself, or just because everyone around you does?”

Sometimes it felt like honesty. Sometimes it felt like attack. Most of the time, she did not know the difference. He would listen to her talk about her family, her fears, her dreams, and then say,

“You’re not built for small.”

She believed him. Because when your first real love names you as bigger than your environment, you let him write his signature on your idea of who you are. He said things like,

“No one will love you like I do.” “You’re too much for most people. That’s why they don’t get you.” “Other men will bore you.”

It sounded like flattery. It was also a spell. He made her feel like regular men were a downgrade. Like calm was an insult. Like steady was an admission of defeat. He did not show up on time. But when he showed up, he showed up fully.

Texted in paragraphs. Called at midnight. Kissed like the world might end on a Tuesday. They fought like it would too. Doors slammed. Phones thrown. Silences that lasted days. Reunions that felt like mercy and withdrawal at the same time. They prayed together sometimes, asking God to bless what they barely controlled.

“We’re just passionate,” he would say after making her cry. “This is what real love looks like. It’s not supposed to be calm.”

She repeated that line to herself more than once. It became an excuse. Then it became a belief. Elias was not a monster. Monsters would have been easier to leave.

He remembered her favourite songs. He noticed when she changed her hair. He held her hands when she talked about things that made other people uncomfortable. He defended her in rooms she wasn’t in. He also disappeared without warning. Reappeared with weak explanations she accepted because the alternative was losing him. Turned every boundary into a negotiation. Turned every doubt she had about him into a question about her own loyalty.

“If you trusted me, you wouldn’t ask that.” “If you really loved me, you’d know I’m not going anywhere.”

Except he did. The first time he left, it was dramatic. Words thrown like plates.

“Maybe we’re just toxic.” “Maybe you deserve better.” “Maybe I’m bad for you.”

She clung to the last one. If he was bad for her, then leaving him would be noble. She could be the strong one. The woman who chose herself. She didn't leave. He did.

She told herself it was temporary. A break, not a break-up. A pause, not an ending. She waited. Days turned into weeks. His name stayed in her phone. His smell stayed in her clothes. His voice stayed in her head.

He moved on to something. Someone. Somewhere. She stayed. Not in his apartment. In his gravity. When he finally came back, because first loves have a way of circling back, he arrived like nothing had happened.

"Hey," he said, as if the word could sweep months under a rug. "I've been thinking about you."

Her body betrayed her. Heart racing. Palms sweating. All the old weather returning at once. They talked. He apologised, but only in a way that still made him sound special.

"I freaked out," he said. "You're a lot. In a good way. I wasn't ready." "I'm sorry I hurt you. I'm sorry I left. I'm here now."

He did not explain what here meant. She did not ask. She heard,

"I've learned my lesson." "I choose you." "I won't do it again."

He had not said those words. She filled in the blanks. They tried again. This time, Diana gave more. Shared more history. Let him see corners of her that no one else had touched.

He made himself at home there. Moved furniture around. Left imprints on the walls. When they fought this time, it hurt differently. Because now he knew where to hit.

"You're obsessed with marriage," he snapped once. "You don't love me. You love the idea of someone staying."

It stung because it carried truth. She did imagine him as her way out of single. Her proof that she was worth committing to. Her first husband in her mind long before there was a proposal. He played with that.

“You’re lucky I even want this,” he said on a bad day. “Other men would have left for less.”

She started to believe that too. When they broke again, if you can call fracture something that was never whole, it was less dramatic. A slow erosion. Calls less frequent. Messages shorter. Apologies thinner. He didn’t say, “We’re done.”

He just stopped building. Eventually, she realised she was the only one still decorating the house in her head. There was no clear last conversation. Just a series of silences that grew longer than their history could justify. He was gone.

This time, he did not come back. Not really. He lingered. In songs. In places. In habits. In every man who looked at her with half his intensity and got dismissed as not it.

Elias had become more than a person. He was an imprint. Her body remembered what her mouth called over. It had learned to associate love with his pattern: High. Low. Hot. Cold. Presence like fire. Absence like withdrawal.

Everything else felt wrong. So when a kind, steady, consistent man arrived, her system went quiet.

“This can’t be it,” she thought. “Where’s the drama? Where’s the dizziness? Where’s the fear?”

She did not realise that what she called boredom was actually peace. Elias stayed in her, not as he really was, but as the story she built around him. In that story, he was the only one who ever really saw her. The only one who matched her. The only one who broke her in a way that proved she had a heart capable of that level of feeling.

She edited his cruelty out of that narrative. She highlighted his tenderness. She italicised his words about no one else ever understanding her. She underlined them in her memory.

Elias became a comparison she never admitted out loud. When a husband raised his voice, she thought, Elias shouted harder. When a husband stayed calm in conflict, she thought, Elias would have fought for this. When a husband reached for her hand in public, she thought, Elias never cared for appearances like that. He was real. Real.

That was the word she had given him. And every man after paid for it. Elias was not her husband on paper. But he was her husband in template. The blueprint for intensity. The standard for connection. The ghost in every bed.

He left her life. He did not leave her. Not yet. Everyone after him met a Diana who had already decided that if love did not shake her the way Elias did, it was not worth rearranging her life for. She did not say it.

She lived it. Elias taught her that love must burn to be real. No one had yet taught her that sometimes, love that burns also burns the house down. That lesson would come later. In vows. In rings. In signatures on lines she thought would finally erase his name from her story.

They didn't. Because before the husbands, before the houses, before the dresses, there was a young woman who let a man become the measurement. And until she met the truth about that, every marriage she stepped into would quietly be asked to compete with a first fire that was never meant to become her whole gospel of love.

Chapter 4

The First Husband

The first man Diana married after Elias was not a monster. That was important. Monsters are easy to leave. Monsters give you clean narratives and clear villains. He was not that. He was the kind of man people pointed to and said, “See? That’s the kind of husband you should want.”

His name was Daniel. He arrived quietly. No grand entrance. No dramatic first line. He noticed her before he announced it. At a dinner where she was not trying to be impressive, where her hair was tied back, where she laughed too loud at someone else’s joke.

He did not flirt with a script. He asked real questions.

“What do you actually enjoy, apart from being busy?” “When was the last time you did something just because you wanted to?”

She shrugged. He waited. Elias had filled silences. Daniel respected them. He texted when he said he would. He called when he said he was too busy to call but wanted to hear her voice anyway. He showed up on time. Not like a performance. Like a habit. He prayed without making a show of it. He worked without boasting about how hard he worked. He listened without turning every story back to himself. Her friends liked him. Her family trusted him faster than they trusted her feelings.

“He’s good for you,” they said.

What they meant was: He’s calm. He’s stable. He’s not Elias. That last part was supposed to be a compliment. It also became the problem. Daniel loved her in a way that did not set the room on fire.

He brought groceries. He fixed things. He learned the names of her relatives and used them properly. He asked about her day and remembered the answer the next time he saw her. He did not make her cry from confusion. He did not disappear for days and reappear with a kiss and a story. He did not call drama “chemistry.” He made plans and kept them. The first time he said, “I love you,” it was not in a fight, or in a panic, or as an apology. It was a Tuesday.

They were cooking. Nothing special. He handed her a knife to chop something, watched the way she hummed under her breath without noticing. Then he said it.

“I love you.”

No build□up. No speech. Just truth dropped in the middle of a normal evening. Her body did not know what to do with that. Love, in her experience, arrived after extremes. After almost losing each other. After a big fight. After fireworks. This felt... underwhelming.

Gentle. Solid. Unremarkable in the best way. She smiled. Said it back. Her mouth formed the words. Her chest did not. Somewhere under her ribs, something whispered: This can’t be it.

But she pushed that voice aside. This is what you’re supposed to want, she told herself. A good man. A steady man. A man who does not confuse you. When he proposed, it was not a viral moment. No string lights. No audience. No photographer hidden in the bushes. Just them, on a bench in a park, where they had walked many times.

He took her hand.

“Diana,” he said, “I don’t promise you excitement every day. But I promise you honesty. I promise you I won’t leave when it’s inconvenient to stay. I promise you I will show up even when I don’t know how to fix what hurts.”

She almost laughed. Not because it was funny. Because it was so uncinematic. No “you’re my entire world.” No “I can’t live without

you.” No “no one will ever love you like I do.” Just vows previewed in plain speech. Her heart, trained by Elias, waited for the big line. The line that would make her feel like she was in a story.

It didn’t come. He just asked, “Will you marry me?” She said yes. Her mouth knew the script. Her mind understood the logic. This is safe. This is good. This is your chance to prove you can do marriage “right.”

On the wedding day, her dress was simpler than people expected. No giant ball gown. No eight bridesmaids. No endless aisle choreography. She looked beautiful. Of course she did. But there was a part of her that watched herself walk and felt like she was watching someone else’s life. The vows felt heavy in her mouth.

“I promise to love you...” “I promise to be faithful...” “I promise to stay...”

Her voice did not shake. She had practice performing conviction. Inside, another sentence ran parallel: I hope this works. I hope this fixes me. I hope this finally proves I’m not the problem. Daniel slipped the ring on. She smiled for the cameras. Everyone clapped. No one saw the ghost sitting in the back row of her mind, arms crossed, leaning against the memories:

Elias, watching every promise and quietly asking, Do you really think he can love you like I did? The first months of marriage were... fine. They learned each other’s rhythms. He liked the bed made every morning. She liked leaving books half□open around the house. He cooked on Sundays. She paid the electricity bill without making a scene about it.

They argued about small things. Dishes. Shoes. The way he chewed. The way she left lights on. Normal. Sometimes she caught herself waiting for the explosion. The big fight. The betrayal. The storm.

It didn't come. Disagreements rose and fell like waves, not tsunamis.

"We don't have to break up to prove this matters," he said once, after a tense conversation about money.

She stared at him. That concept was new. In her history, conflict had always threatened the relationship. Argument meant brink. Brink meant drama. Drama meant intensity. Intensity meant love. Daniel refused that equation.

"I'm not going anywhere," he repeated often, not as a line, but as a decision he kept living out.

She believed him in her head. Her body kept flinching anyway. One night, he found her sitting on the floor in the hallway, back against the wall, breathing too fast.

"What's wrong?" he asked, kneeling down, not touching her yet.

She struggled to explain.

"Nothing happened," she said.

"That's not true," he answered quietly. "Something happened inside you."

She hated that he could see that.

"I'm just... waiting," she admitted.

"For what?"

"For you to leave."

His face didn't register offence. Just sadness.

"Why would I leave?" he asked.

"Because they all do," she thought. Because one already did so loudly that every silence since sounds like preparation.

She didn't say that. Instead she said, "I don't know. I just... don't trust this."

"This?"

"Us," she whispered.

He didn't defend himself. He didn't launch into a speech about his integrity. He just sat with her. On the floor. In the hallway. In the quiet.

"You don't have to trust me perfectly to be here," he said eventually. "You just have to tell the truth when you can't."

It should have disarmed her. In some ways, it did. In others, it made her feel exposed. Vulnerability without drama felt naked. No big fight to justify the emotion. No breakup to dangle as threat. Just... honest fear sitting between them. She wasn't used to that. In the months that followed, Diana oscillated between leaning in and pulling away.

Lean in: she laughed at his jokes, she lay on his chest, she told him about childhood moments she had never told anyone. Pull away: she stayed late at work when she didn't need to, she slept on the edge of the bed, she picked small flaws and magnified them into reasons this could never be "it". He noticed.

"You're here," he said once, "but you keep your bags packed in your mind."

That description was too accurate. She wanted to argue. She didn't. Because he was right. She had built a life where exit plans were part of the furniture. Even in a good marriage.

Especially in a good marriage. Good meant more to lose. Sometimes, she found herself provoking him. Late replies. Withholding affection. Pushing on his limits. Not to see if he would become abusive.

To see if he would become Elias. Raise his voice. Say something unforgivable. Prove that all men were the same. He didn't. He got frustrated, of course. He was human. He spoke sharply once or twice. Apologised afterwards. Did not turn apology into manipulation.

It confused her. Part of her missed the high of the chaos. Part of her liked sleeping without wondering if tonight was the night everything would blow up. She lived between those parts. Daniel tried. Tried to love her past without losing himself in it. Tried to listen without letting every story turn him into therapist instead of husband. Tried to make room for her ghosts without letting them run the house.

He was not perfect. He forgot anniversaries. He made jokes at the wrong time. He underestimated how deep some cracks were. He was not a saint. He got tired. He got impatient. He wanted a wife who trusted him and resented sometimes that he had to keep proving he wasn't someone else. But he did not deserve the weight she put on his back. When the cracks finally showed, they were not dramatic. No affair. No scandal.

Just a quiet accumulation of unsaid things. Her distance. His fatigue. Her comparisons. His confusion.

"You're not here," he said one day at the kitchen table.

"I'm literally sitting right in front of you," she replied.

"That's not what I mean."

He looked at her ring.

"Who are you married to in your head?" he asked.

The question landed like a verdict she didn't know how to appeal. She opened her mouth to say, "You." The word got stuck. He saw the hesitation.

"That's what I thought," he said softly.

There was no shouting. No slammed doors. Just the quiet understanding that he had been competing with someone he had never met. Elias. Not as a man. As a measurement. Daniel did not leave that day. He stayed longer than that.

They tried counselling. They tried weekends away. They tried new routines, new prayers, new conversations. But some fractures happen so early you don't realise the foundation was cracked before you even built the house. Eventually, they sat across from each other in another office with another person asking,

“Do you want to keep trying?”

He said yes. She said something like yes. Her eyes said, “I'm tired of failing at this.” They ended, in the end, without a villain. He signed papers with shaking hands. She signed with a heart that felt both guilty and... relieved. He had been a good man. Not perfect. But decent. Their marriage had not collapsed because he was cruel or because she was evil.

It had collapsed because she walked into it with an unsafe definition of love and expected him to redeem it. He couldn't. No one could. Years later, when people said, “She married again? She just can't stay,” they rarely mentioned Daniel's name. If they did, it was as a footnote.

“He was a good guy. I don't know why it didn't work.”

Diana knew. Even if she couldn't fully admit it yet. The tragedy of the first husband was not that he hurt her. It was that he didn't— and she still left because her heart had been trained to only recognise love when it came dressed as a wound.

Chapter 5

The House She Couldn't Enter

Diana had keys to houses she never really lived in. On paper, she belonged there. Her name on the lease. Her clothes in the wardrobe. Her toothbrush by the sink. Her shoes by the door. But there is a difference between being in a house and inhabiting it. She learned that slowly.

The first house she shared with a husband was modest. Two bedrooms. Thin walls. A small balcony that tried its best to be a view. People congratulated them.

“You’re building a life.” “You’re doing it right.” “You’re finally settled.”

Settled. The word sat on her chest like a piece of furniture she did not remember buying. In the beginning, she did all the things a wife is supposed to do. She unpacked. She folded. She arranged. Picture frames on shelves. Cushions on couches. Mugs lined up like a quiet army ready to hold their mornings.

It looked like a home. Then came the evenings. He would sit on the couch, remote in hand, asking how her day was. She would answer. She would ask his. They would talk. On the surface, nothing was wrong.

Underneath, a small part of her stood in the doorway, coat still on, just in case. It was not about Daniel alone. Or the next husband. Or the next. The pattern was the same. The house was always a few steps ahead of her heart.

She moved in her things. Her heart stayed in storage. Friends came over and said,

“It feels so you in here.”

She smiled. They meant the colours, the candles, the books. They did not know she had furnished the space the way people furnish a hotel room when they plan to stay one week and pretend it is a life. Enough to feel comfortable. Not enough to feel trapped.

At night, when the house was quiet, she would walk through the rooms like a guest who had arrived before the host. Kitchen. Living room. Bedroom. She would touch surfaces. Table. Chair. Window. Everything solid. Everything theirs.

Still, something inside her kept asking: When do we go home? It was a cruel question. Because she was home, according to everyone. According to her own signatures.

The walls did not know she was missing. The neighbours did not know she was visiting. Her husband did not know he was living with someone who always kept one foot at the threshold. There were days when she tried to force herself in. She cooked as if recipes could root her. She rearranged furniture as if moving the couch could move her heart. She lit candles and told herself,

“Feel this. This is your life. Be here.”

Sometimes it worked. For a few minutes. For a few hours. Then the old itch returned. Don’t relax too much. Don’t open all the boxes. Don’t hang every picture. You never know.

It did not matter if the man was good or careless, calm or chaotic, steady or unstable. The house itself felt temporary. In one marriage, she had a big kitchen with white cabinets and a fridge covered in magnets from trips that had almost made them happy. She would stand there, hand on the cold metal, and feel like she was walking through someone else’s life. In another, the bedroom had a view of

the city at night.

Lights like constellations. Walls painted warm. Friends said, “This is goals.” She nodded. She slept with her back half turned to the person beside her, heart half turned to a past that refused to leave the bed. If you had asked her, she would have said she was grateful.

“This is more than I ever had growing up.” “This is a blessing.” “This is stability.”

All true. None of it changed the fact that she often felt like she was standing in a doorway watching herself live. Husbands noticed in different ways. One said,

“You’re always ready to go somewhere else. Even when we’re just watching a movie.”

Another said,

“You decorate rooms like you’re staging a set, not building a home.”

Another did not have the words. He just grew quieter, his own presence pulling back from someone who seemed halfway gone even when she was right there. It would have been easy to blame them. To say they did not make her feel safe enough. Seen enough. Known enough. And sometimes, that was true.

But in the still moments, alone, she had to admit: No matter how different the houses were, the feeling was the same. The doors were unlocked. The closets open. The bed made. She was the one standing outside herself. There is a kind of absence that does not look like leaving.

It looks like doing everything expected, saying everything right, showing up in every photo, and never letting your weight rest fully on the life you chose. She could hear her own footsteps in those houses. The way they hesitated on thresholds. The way they sped up near exits. She knew every back door. Every spare key. Every friend she

could stay with “just for a few days” if everything collapsed. Preparedness, she called it.

Wisdom. Self-protection. But sometimes, late at night, sitting on a sofa someone else had carried up the stairs, she wondered: What does it do to a soul to never sit all the way down? The houses began to blur. Different walls. Different furniture. Different men.

Same sensation. Like trying to pray in a language she had never fully learned. Like borrowing a dress that fit but did not yet feel like hers. She knew how to host. Dinner parties. Game nights. Bible studies. Birthday gatherings. She knew how to make a house feel alive for other people.

But when the door closed behind the last guest, silence had questions. Do you live here or do you just maintain it? Are you building a marriage or curating an exhibit called “My Life Is Together”? Standing in the kitchen one night, lights off, only the streetlamp outside painting soft rectangles on the floor, another truth surfaced: This was not just about men.

Or vows. Or Elias. This was about the part of Diana that had never fully moved into herself. How could she inhabit a house when she had never really inhabited her own heart? She had been a guest there too. Visiting. Judging. Rearranging. Leaving when it got uncomfortable.

The houses she couldn't enter were not just made of brick and paint. They were made of shoulds and musts, of good wives don't and holy women always. She had built an entire life around the idea that if the house looked right, the heart would eventually catch up. But walls cannot do the work that only truth can do. One day, in yet another kitchen, with yet another mug warming her hands, she realised:

“I have been married to addresses more than to people.”

It was a harsh thought. But it fit. She had loved the idea of being settled so much that she kept signing contracts on lives she never

intended to fully occupy. It was never only a place. It was every version of herself that looked complete from the outside and hollow in the centre.

Every time she walked over a threshold, carrying boxes, carrying hope, carrying fear, some part of her stayed on the porch. Watching. Waiting. Ready. Ready for what? For the day someone would say, “This isn’t working.” For the day she would say it first. For the day the walls would remind her that she once believed love needed to hurt to be real. This chapter of her life was a hallway of houses.

None of them entirely wrong. None of them entirely right. Each one asking the same quiet question every time she put her key in the lock: Will you live here or just visit until the next life you think will finally feel like home? Diana did not have the answer yet. But slowly, without knowing it, she was starting to suspect:

The problem was not the architecture. The problem was that she kept arriving with her bags packed and her heart still standing at the door.

Chapter 6

The Men Who Tried

Not every man in Diana's story came to break her. Some came to build. Or at least to try. They did not arrive perfect. They arrived willing.

Willing to listen. Willing to stay. Willing to hold space for a woman whose heart was already crowded. It would be easier to pretend all of them were careless, lazy, faithless, cruel. That would keep the narrative clean. She married badly. She left for good reason. End of story. But the truth had more weight than that.

There were men who loved her as best as they knew how and still walked away with wounds. Men who had to learn that loving someone whose heart still answered to an old wound is a kind of fatigue you cannot explain to people who have only known simple love.

The Patient One

There was the man who thought patience could fix anything. He had heard her story. At least the parts she was ready to tell. He knew about Elias. He knew there had been divorce. He knew she carried shame like a second skin. He told himself,

"I can handle that."

He wasn't naive. He just believed in effort. When she pulled away, he leaned in. When she doubted, he reassured. When she tested him, he took the exam.

"You're safe with me," he said more than once.

She wanted to believe him. He mistook wanting for being able. He waited when she went quiet. He forgave delayed replies. He accepted that sometimes her “I’m fine” meant, “I’m holding a whole storm and don’t trust you enough to see it.” He did not complain at first. He told his friends,

“She’s been through things. I knew what I was signing up for.”

What he did not say out loud was that sometimes loving her felt like loving someone standing behind glass. Close. Visible. Untouchable. He tapped gently.

“Let me in.”

She smiled through the glass. Nodded. Did not unlock the door. Patience is holy until it becomes self-erasure. Eventually, he realised he was measuring time by how long it had been since she last let herself be fully present with him. Weeks. Months.

“I don’t want to be another man you survive,” he told her once. “I wanted to be someone you could rest with.”

She heard it. She believed he meant it. She still did not know how to surrender to it. When he left, he did it quietly. No speech. No blame.

Just a sentence that stayed with her:

“I love you. But I don’t know how to be with someone who keeps loving me like I’m a threat.”

He tried. He was not strong enough to overpower her fear. He was never supposed to be.

The Builder

There was the man who thought he could rebuild her life with structure. He brought plans. Budgets. Schedules.

“Let’s fix this,” he would say.

Meaning bills. Habits. Patterns. He was not trying to control her. Not intentionally. He had grown up with chaos. He hated it. He prided himself on stability. He looked at Diana and thought,

“She needs what I’ve built for myself.”

So he offered it.

“I’ll handle the finances.” “I’ll deal with the landlord.” “I’ll talk to your family.” “I’ll be the covering.”

Some of it helped. There is relief in not carrying everything alone. But slowly, his help became a hallway where her own agency started to echo. When she questioned him, he heard ingratitude. When she asked to handle something herself, he heard rejection.

“I’m just trying to make your life easier,” he protested.

She could not always explain that sometimes the easiest life is not the truest one. He tried to give her what he thought every woman wanted: a man who takes care of things. What he did not see was that part of her wanted to prove she could stand on her own legs.

“Let me carry you,” he said.

She wanted to answer,

“I need you to walk beside me instead.”

She didn’t. So he kept carrying. Until his arms got tired. Until his resentment grew teeth.

“I did all this for you,” he said one day, listing sacrifices, expenses, decisions.

She felt the weight of that sentence more than any bill. She realised then: He had built a life around her, but not always with her. He had tried. Sincerely. Deeply.

He had also made her his project. Projects are easier to leave than people. When they broke, he told others,

“I gave her everything.”

He wasn't lying. He just did not know that everything given from the outside cannot repair a crack on the inside that the owner refuses to name.

The Gentle One

There was the man who loved her softly. No raised voice. No slammed doors. No dramatic exits. He did not confuse calm with weakness. He had done his own work. Read. Reflected. Learned when to speak and when to sit quietly.

He knew enough about pain not to take every reaction personally. He knew enough about himself to admit when he was overwhelmed. He touched her like she might flinch. Asked before he assumed. Gave her time.

“I'm not here to earn you,” he said. “I'm here to know you.”

She had never heard it put like that. It scared her. Because being known meant letting someone see the parts that did not match the story she liked to tell. He was the one who noticed how often she laughed when she was uncomfortable. How often she turned deep conversations into jokes. How often she dismissed her own needs as “dramatic” before he even had a chance to respond.

“You apologise for existing a lot,” he pointed out once.

It irritated her.

“I don't,” she said reflexively.

“You just did,” he replied, gently.

He held up mirrors, but he did it without sharpness. The problem was not his reflection. It was her tolerance for it. Some nights, she felt a strange peace sitting with him. No performance. No test. No storm.

Her heart did not know what to do with that. Peace, for someone who has lived in crises, can feel like absence. She found herself picking at flaws just to feel something. He forgot a small detail she had told him last week. She turned it into evidence that he did not really listen. He took longer to respond to a text because he was at work. She spun it into a story about being unimportant.

He could see it happening.

“This isn’t about me,” he said gently once, after she snapped over something tiny.

“I know,” she replied.

It only made her angrier. He deserved someone who did not make him study pain he had not caused. Being gentle with someone who expects violence is exhausting. He tried. Stayed longer than his friends advised. Held on through more cycles than wisdom recommended.

But gentleness without reciprocation turns into self-harm. When he left, it was with tears in his eyes, not venom in his words.

“I love you,” he said. “I just can’t be the only one fighting for a version of love that doesn’t look like war.”

He left behind a new pain for her: Proof that even good men reach a limit.

The Exhausted Ones

Not all the men who tried got names in her memory. Some were brief chapters. Short attempts. Almosts. The man who dated her for a few months and realised he was always trying to convince her she wasn’t a burden. The man who sat in premarital counselling and watched her answer every question with theological precision and emotional distance.

The man who said,

“I feel like you’re waiting for me to fail,”

and watched her shrug because she could not promise she wasn’t. They each added something to the ledger. Not of guilt. Of evidence. Evidence that the problem was not just that men hurt her.

It was also that some men tried to love her and found themselves trying to prove they were not ghosts.

“You were never enough for yourself,” one of them said in frustration. “How were we supposed to be enough for you?”

Harsh. But not entirely wrong.

The Uncomfortable Truth

Diana liked to tell herself that her patterns were born only from wounds. From Elias. From childhood. From culture. From church. All of that was real. But this chapter of her life forced her to see something else: There were men who came without knives, and she still bled on them.

There were men who brought flowers, and she still braced for impact. There were men who offered rest, and she still slept with her shoes on. They tried. Not perfectly. Not always wisely. But they tried.

And their trying stripped her of the easy script.

“I only behave like this because men are trash.”

The men who tried were not trash. They were tired. Tired of being cross-examined for every kindness. Tired of proving their difference from ghosts they had never met. Tired of walking into houses where the furniture was already arranged for someone else. They left, each in their own way. Some with anger. Some with sadness. Some with relief.

Diana was left with the echo. The men who tried did not prove that she was unlovable. They proved something harder to swallow: Love is not enough when your definition of it is still married to your

first wound. Until that changed, every man who tried would eventually become another story about how she could not keep what she claimed she wanted.

And that story, unexamined, would become yet another reason to run straight back into the arms of the only version of love her body still recognised: the one that hurt.

Chapter 7

The Men Who Hurt Her

Not every man who entered Diana's life came with patience. Some came with appetite. They saw the cracks and called them doors. They saw her hunger to be chosen and learned where to place the hook. By then, Diana already had a reputation.

Divorced. Complicated. Difficult. Too much. Some men heard those words and felt warned. Others heard them and felt invited.

The Controller

He did not call himself controlling. He called himself a leader. From the beginning, he framed himself as an answer.

"I know what it means to be a man." "I know how to protect a woman." "I know how to handle someone with a past."

He talked about order. Structure. Respect. Image. At first, it sounded like safety. He opened doors. Paid bills. Remembered details. Made decisions quickly. He used words like "we" and "us" in ways that made her feel like chaos might finally have a stronger hand to answer to. Then the we started eating you.

"Don't wear that. It makes people talk." "Don't post that. It makes me look bad." "Don't go there. Wives don't need to be in those places."

He reminded her of her reputation as if it were a stain he had been kind enough to cover.

"You know people already think you're unstable," he would say. "Let's not give them more reasons."

He framed restrictions as protection.

“I’m just trying to guard you.” “I’m just trying to help you grow.”
“I’m just trying to make sure people respect us.”

She had been told all her life that a good man leads. It took her a while to notice that his leadership required her disappearance. Every time she pushed back, he pulled out her past. The divorces. The rumours. The men before him. The threat of losing someone willing to choose a woman like her.

“You think another man will accept your history?” he asked once.
“You should be grateful.”

Grateful. Not for kindness. For tolerance. He used her shame as leverage. When she cried, he called it overreaction. When she disagreed, he called it disrespect. When she went quiet, he called it peace.

It was not peace. It was resignation. Some nights, she lay beside him and imagined saying,

“I am not your redemption project.” “I am not your proof that you can handle a complicated woman.” “I am not your trophy for surviving my past.”

She didn’t. He wasn’t always harsh. He sometimes held her gently. He sometimes apologised. But apologies that never change behaviour become another form of control. He hurt her, not with bruises, but with slowly shrinking walls.

By the time she left, she had to relearn how to make simple decisions without asking permission.

The Punisher

He introduced himself as honest.

“I don’t sugarcoat,” he said. “I say things as they are.”

What he did not say was that his honesty had teeth. He liked the fact that she had a past. It gave him material.

“You know I’m not like the others,” he would say. “I chose you despite everything.”

Despite. The word sat like a stone in every compliment. He reminded her often.

“You’re lucky I accepted you.” “Most men wouldn’t deal with a woman like you.” “Do you know how many guys would walk away if they knew everything I know?”

At first, she took it as sacrifice. He stayed knowing all that. He must be serious. Then she started noticing how often he reached for her history as a weapon. Whenever she challenged him, he brought up her divorces.

Whenever she asked for more, he brought up her track record.

“You’re talking like you have options,” he snapped once. “Reality check: you don’t.”

He wore her past like armour and swung it like a sword. In arguments, he would say,

“Who are you to talk about commitment?” “You broke vows. Don’t lecture me on faithfulness.” “You’ve left more men than I’ve dated.”

It was not that he never had a point. It was that he used truth to humiliate, not heal. She began to apologise for things she hadn’t done yet, just in case.

“I’m sorry,” became a reflex.

Not a confession. The Punisher hurt her by convincing her that any standard she held was hypocrisy. That any boundary she set was ingratitude. That any request she made was out of place because her past had disqualified her from asking. He did not hit her.

He just made sure she never forgot that, in his eyes, she was always on thin ice.

The Charmer

Then there was the man who felt almost familiar. Not Elias. That was the problem. Close enough for her body to remember. Intense. Magnetic. Funny in a way that made people turn their chairs towards him.

He knew how to make chaos taste like adventure. He messaged late. Called often. Appeared with that half-smile that suggested he knew he should not be there and had decided to be anyway. Her body recognised the pattern before her mind named it. The rush. The stomach drop. The feeling that life had started speaking in capital letters again. He listened.

At least at first. He repeated her sentences back to her with slightly better phrasing.

"You're not built for small," he said.

She should have recognised the spell. He talked about God too. Enough to sound deep. Not enough to be accountable.

"We're different," he told her. "People like us don't do normal." "Our story won't look like anyone else's."

It sounded romantic. It was also permission to avoid responsibility. He cancelled plans and returned with grand gestures. He disappeared and came back with beautiful explanations. He made unpredictability feel like passion. At first, Diana almost fell back into the old script. High. Low. Break. Reunion.

But something in her had shifted. Maybe it was the gentle men who had come before. Maybe it was prayer. Maybe it was the exhaustion of recognising the same wound in a different shirt. When he raised his voice and called it passion, a small voice inside her said: No. That is disrespect.

When he ignored her boundaries and called it spontaneity, the same voice whispered: No. That is disregard. He still hurt her. Not because she fully believed him.

Because part of her still wanted to. He reminded her how easy it was to slip back into a story where danger feels like chemistry. The Charmer did not stay. He did not have to. He had already done his damage by proving that the wrong thing can still feel familiar enough to miss.

The Spiritual Manipulator

If the Controller wanted her behaviour, the Spiritual Manipulator wanted her conscience. He knew the verses. He knew the tone. He knew how to dress his preferences as divine instruction.

“God is a God of order,” he would say when she disagreed. “Submission is protection,” he would preach when she hesitated.

He adored testimony. Loved telling people how he had “taken a chance” on a woman with such a complicated past. In private, he kept score.

“I forgave you for that,” he would remind her. “I covered you when people talked.” “I stood by you when others wouldn’t.”

He framed his presence as grace she could never afford to lose. Whenever she considered leaving, he dropped spiritual grenades.

“Be careful not to step out of God’s will.” “Divorce opens doors you don’t want to see open again.” “Don’t let the enemy use your emotions.”

He talked about the devil more than he talked about his own behaviour. He called her concerns attacks. He called her discernment fear. He called her boundaries walls God wanted to break. He hurt her by taking the most sacred part of her — her desire to honour God — and turning it into a leash. The worst part was that some of what he said had truth in it. She did want to grow. She did want to stop

running. She did want to honour covenant.

He knew that. He counted on it.

“God won’t give you another man like me,” he said once.

She did not answer out loud. Inside, something darker replied: I hope not.

The Truth She Avoided

Some men did not wound Diana because she was hard to love. They wounded her because they knew she had already been taught to confuse pain with proof. They saw how quickly her shoulders softened when someone said,

“I’m still here after everything you’ve done.”

They noticed the way she apologised for existing too loudly. For needing too much. For having a history. They read her guilt like a manual. Pressed where it hurt. Called it honesty. Called it leadership. Called it covering. Called it love.

She did not deserve the harm. That sentence mattered. She had to learn to say it without immediately listing her own faults. She did not deserve the harm. But sometimes, she stayed.

Not because she liked being hurt. Because the hurt felt familiar. Familiarity is its own drug. The raised tone that sounded like home. The cold shoulder that felt like early rejection. The spiritual language that echoed old sermons. The half-apology that fit perfectly into the groove Elias had carved years ago. The men who tried made her feel guilty.

The men who hurt her made her feel at home. That was the part she did not want to admit. Because guilt can be confessed. You can say,

“I’m sorry.” “I was wrong.” “I hurt you.”

You can write it. Pray it. Name it in rooms where healing is supposed to begin. Familiarity is harder to surrender. It means admitting that some of the harm felt more natural than the healthy love that came before.

It means confessing not just the wounds, but the ways you kept returning to the same shape because your body knew the road by heart. This chapter was not written to balance scales of blame. It was written so that when Diana stood before God, before herself, before anyone she might try to love again, she could say: Some men tried and I bled on them. Some men saw the blood and pressed harder.

Both are true. And if I want a different story, I cannot afford to forget either.

Chapter 8

The Ghost in Every Marriage

Elias was not present at any of Diana's weddings. Not physically. He did not sit in the back row. He did not object. He did not send a message before the vows. And still, somehow, he attended all of them. His name was not on the invitations. His face was not in the photos. His voice was not heard in the speeches.

But he was there. In the way her stomach tightened when the pastor said, "for as long as you both shall live." In the way her eyes flickered, for half a second, as if they were checking a memory before agreeing. Every marriage Diana entered had three people in it: Diana. The man who said "I do." And the memory of Elias.

The Ghost in Comparison

She did not say his name out loud. She promised herself she wouldn't. She promised God too.

"This is new," she would whisper. "This is clean. I won't bring him into this."

But comparison does not need a name to operate. It just needs a scale. Elias had become the scale. If a husband raised his voice, she thought, Elias shouted harder. Maybe he cared more.

If a husband stayed calm during conflict, she thought, Elias would have fought for this. He would not have let it go so easily. He would have made me feel it. If a husband gave her space, she felt abandoned. If he checked in often, she felt watched. No one after Elias was allowed to be themselves.

They were all sitting for a test they did not know existed. She called it instinct. Discernment. Chemistry. Sometimes it was just this: You are not him, and I do not know how to love someone without putting them on a scale I never told them they were on. Elias became the language her body used to translate love.

If a man did not speak pain fluently, she thought he had nothing to say.

The Ghost in the Bedroom

No explicit details. This is not that story. But bodies remember. They remember who first taught them what desire feels like. Who first made their hands shake. Their breath shorten. Their skin carry certain names like electricity. Elias had been the first man to inhabit her in that way.

Not just physically. Deeply. Her body had taken notes. Fire here. Fear there. High here. Collapse there. Years later, in marital beds that should have felt safe, she sometimes lay beside men who had done nothing wrong and felt nothing.

Not because they were unkind. Not because they were unskilled. Because her body had been trained to associate desire with danger. Gentle hands felt confusing. Predictable affection felt flat. Consistent touch felt muted. She did not always think of Elias consciously in those moments.

But his pattern sat underneath. He had made desire feel like a fight. He had made closeness feel like a bargain. He had made her body think that to be wanted meant being a little bit afraid. In a quiet, faithful marriage, where the lights were warm and the sheets were clean and the man beside her wasn't going anywhere, she sometimes felt like she was acting. She responded. She participated. She did what lovers do. But somewhere inside, another script ran:

This isn't what love is supposed to feel like. It's too still. Too safe. Too easy. She did not miss Elias as a person in those moments. She

missed the version of herself who had once mistaken adrenaline for aliveness.

The Ghost in Conflict

Conflict reveals what you believe love is allowed to be. With Elias, arguments had been storms. Words thrown. Threats implied. Break-ups dramatised. Make-ups that felt like oxygen after drowning. Her body learned that if a fight did not end with someone sobbing, someone leaving, someone clutching the doorframe, it wasn't serious. So when a husband stayed seated during disagreement, she read it as disinterest.

When he said,

“I need a minute to calm down before we talk,”

she heard,

“I don't care enough to stay in this with you.”

She pushed. Raised her voice just to see if she could pull him into the storm.

“Say something,” she would insist. “React. Show me you care.”

If he refused to escalate, she felt alone. If he did escalate, if he matched her volume, her suspicion flared. There you are, she thought. Now I recognise this. Elias had corrupted the scale.

Intensity felt real. Regulation felt fake. Calm felt like distance. Repair without explosion felt like avoidance. She picked fights she did not need, just to check if the ground was solid. Just to see if this man would leave the way one already had. The ghost was not only in the fights she had. It was in the fights she created.

The Ghost in Peace

Peace is hard to trust when your favourite memories were forged in chaos. Sundays in quiet houses, with grocery bags on the counter

and laundry humming in the background, should have felt like blessing. Sometimes, for a few minutes, they did. She would look at a husband napping on the couch, television low, phone face down, and feel a wave of gratitude. Then, almost immediately, another feeling would rise behind it.

Restlessness. This can't be all there is, a voice in her whispered. Where are the highs? The drama? The declarations? The scenes? Stability felt like lack. Like something was missing.

She had been disciplined by stories where love was proven by what people were willing to lose, burn, break. Peace had never been marketed to her as romantic. So when she got it, she called it boredom. There were moments when she sabotaged it on purpose. Started pointless arguments. Answered an old message she should have deleted. Flirted with the idea of leaving just to see how quickly the man in front of her would panic.

If he panicked, she felt validated. If he didn't, she felt unwanted. There was no scenario where peace was allowed to simply be enough. Elias had become the ghost in her calm. The absence of drama reminded her of his absence.

She equated the two. If it doesn't hurt, it must not be deep.

The Confession

It would be easy to say that she was haunted. That this was something done to her. Something she had no say in. There is partial truth there. Pain does not ask permission before it memorises you.

But there came a point where Diana had to admit something harder:

"I was not only haunted," she would later write. "I was loyal to the haunting."

She defended it. Protected it. Explained it to herself in late-night monologues. She called it first love. She called it destiny. She called it

the one time she had ever really felt. Letting go of Elias felt, for years, like betraying the girl she had been with him. Younger. Wilder. Reckless in a way that made her feel like she was starring in her own movie. She did not just miss him.

She missed her. The her who did not yet know how much this would cost. The her who believed that any love that big must be sacred. The her who thought surviving a relationship like that made her special. There is ego in pain too. In being able to say,

“No one understands what we had.” “No one has loved me like that since.” “No one could handle me the way he did.”

Walking away from the ghost meant admitting that what she once called rare was also, in many ways, harmful. It meant saying: He was not the only one who ever really saw me. He was just the first one who made me feel seen in a way that nearly destroyed me. And I turned that into a template without checking if it was true.

The ghost in every marriage was not only Elias. It was the version of Diana who still believed that the love that almost destroyed her was the only love that had ever been real. And until that woman was grieved, really grieved, every husband would keep sleeping beside a memory. A memory she had kept alive because she did not yet know who she was without it. This was not yet a funeral.

But it was the first time she admitted something had to die. Not Elias. Not the past. Not even the girl who loved him. But the altar she had built to him in the centre of her understanding of love.

Funerals are not clean. They come with laughter. Stories. Denial. Tears. But they begin with one thing: acknowledging that something cannot remain the reference point for every decision anymore. Until she buried the ghost, marriage would keep feeling like a haunted house.

And it would never be fair to ask another man to move into what she refused to finally let go.

Chapter 9

The Marriage That Almost Saved Her

By the time Diana met Michael, she had already buried enough versions of forever to stop using the word lightly. She did not meet him at an altar. She met him in the middle of her own reconstruction. Therapy had begun. Prayer had changed. Less, “God, send me someone.” More, “God, show me why I keep choosing this.”

She was not healed. But she was no longer completely asleep. Michael was not the most intense man she had loved. He was clear. You could tell what he felt by where he stood, what he did, how he stayed.

He did not make promises quickly. He did not flinch from her history. He listened. Really listened. Not like a man collecting details to use later. Not like a man trying to seem deep. He listened like someone who had practice holding other people’s truths without needing to become the hero in them.

A Different Beginning

Their beginning felt almost unremarkable. No whirlwind. No confession at 3 a.m. No “I’ve never felt this way before” on the second date. He took her to places where conversation could breathe. Cafés. Parks. Church, sometimes, but not as a performance. He did not rush to define the relationship.

He also did not vanish. Steady pursuit.

“I don’t want to rush you,” he said early on. “But I also don’t want to pretend I’m not interested.”

She appreciated the honesty. By then, she had met enough cowards to know that clarity is a form of courage. When he learned about Elias, he did not call him “the one that got away.” He called him, softly,

“the one who taught you the wrong language.”

She winced. Because it fit. He knew her record. The marriages. The leaving. The trying. The failing.

“I don’t need you to convince me you’ve changed,” he told her. “I need you to tell me when you feel yourself disappearing.”

No one had ever phrased it like that.

Choosing Slowly

When he proposed, it was not in ignorance. He knew that loving her meant loving a woman who had learned to keep one hand on the door. He also knew he could not heal her for her.

“I’m not your last chance,” he said. “I’m a man who loves you. But I love myself enough not to disappear inside your story.”

She said yes anyway. Not because she believed marriage would save her. Not anymore. Because she believed this was the closest she had come to a love that did not need to become a rescue mission to be real. Their wedding was smaller this time.

Fewer guests. Less spectacle. No need to prove anything to anyone. People whispered anyway.

“Again?” “Maybe this is the one.” “She looks calmer.” “She looks scared.”

They were not entirely wrong. She did look calmer because she had stopped pretending she didn’t know what she was capable of. She did look scared because this time, if it broke, she knew the fault lines would not all belong to someone else.

Learning Peace

Marriage with Michael did not feel like a movie. It felt like practice. He left notes on the fridge. She actually read them. He asked, “How was therapy?” She answered without turning it into a joke. They fought.

Of course they did. But fights were different now. She caught herself mid-spiral more often. Paused. Breathed. There were nights she would say,

“I’m not here. I’m years ago, arguing with someone else. Let me come back.”

He respected that. He also held her accountable.

“I’m not him,” he would remind her, when she flinched at a tone that was not threatening.

“I’m not them,” he would say, when she braced for abandonment over a simple miscommunication.

He called out her patterns without calling her names.

“You’re looking for reasons to run,” he said once, after she turned one difficult week into a verdict. “Can we talk about why?”

She hated that conversation. She also knew this was the kind of man who might have been able to love her and be loved by her, if she had met him with less ghost in the room.

Sabotaging Peace

Healing is not a straight line. There were days she felt almost normal. Cooking with music on. Laughing with him over something small. Praying together in a way that did not feel staged. Then there were days when boredom came dressed as danger. Her body still missed adrenaline.

Michael would be reading on the couch, content, and she would feel irritated. Not at him. At the absence of crisis. Is this it? a cruel voice in her head would ask. Is this what you broke your life for?

Groceries. Shared bills. Quiet evenings. She caught herself opening old messages she should have deleted. Checking old photos. Touching old scars. Not because she wanted to go back. Because part of her still used pain as a way to feel alive.

Michael sensed it.

“You’re elsewhere,” he said one night. “Where did you go?”

She could not answer. Because where she went did not have an address. It was a version of herself that still believed peace was a downgrade.

The Almost-Turn

There was a moment where this marriage could have turned. Not into perfection. Into longevity. A particular fight. Not about something huge.

Money. Family. Plans. She felt cornered. Not by him. By intimacy. He had seen more of her than most.

He had gotten closer to the rooms she usually kept locked. She panicked. Old reflexes woke up. Raise your voice. Say something you cannot unsay. Find a flaw big enough to justify leaving. She almost did.

Words reached her tongue that would have started the collapse.

“You’re not enough.” “You don’t get me.” “This isn’t working.”

She heard them in her mind. For the first time, she also heard another voice. Pause. Check if the threat is real or if your past is shouting over the present. She paused.

Only for a second. Sometimes a second is enough. Sometimes it is not. Michael saw the battle in her face.

“What’s happening?” he asked softly.

She could have told him then. Everything. The ghost. The fear. The boredom that was not boredom. The grief of losing the only version of love she had known how to recognise. She didn’t. She changed the subject.

Turned the fight into logistics. Let the true conversation die before it was born. He felt it. The door closing. The wall returning. He did not leave.

Not then. But something in him took a step back. You can love someone deeply and still reach a limit on how many times you are willing to stand in front of their self-destruction and call it love.

The Crack

The marriage did not end in a single moment. There was no dramatic suitcase at the door. No shattered plate. No late-night confession of an affair. Just wear. Wear on his patience. Wear on her hope. Wear on their ability to keep believing they were on the same team. He started sleeping facing the other way a little more often. She started working late a little more than necessary.

They still ate together. Still went to church. Still smiled in photos. Anyone looking from the outside would have called it fine. Fine is often where things die. One day, sitting at a table that had seen more meals than real conversations, Michael said,

“I love you.”

He had said it before. This time it sounded different. Less like a declaration. More like a fact he was checking one last time.

“I love you,” he repeated. “But I don’t know if you believe me without pain to prove it.”

She opened her mouth to protest. Closed it. Because he was right. She had spent years equating suffering with sincerity. He continued.

“I don’t want to hurt you to make you feel this is real. And I won’t stay if the only version of love you recognise is the one that breaks you.”

Tears came. Not dramatic sobs. Just quiet, stubborn tears she had tried to hold back.

“I’m trying,” she said.

“I know,” he answered.

And that was what made it hurt more. Trying, sometimes, is not enough when the pattern you are fighting is older than your willingness to kill it. They did not decide that day. They just named something they could no longer pretend wasn’t there.

The Almost Salvation

People say things like,

“He almost saved her.”

It is not quite true. Michael was not a saviour. He was a mirror. He showed Diana what it could feel like to be loved in a way that did not demand self-betrayal. He also showed her how loud her old gods still were.

The god of intensity. The god of being chosen no matter the cost. The god of drama as identity. She stood at a crossroads she had never reached so clearly before. On one side: the familiar high of sabotaging peace and then calling it destiny. On the other:

the slow, quiet work of staying in a love that did not constantly threaten to leave. She hesitated too long. By the time she chose, part of him was already gone. They divorced without scandal. No one villainized him. No one fully understood her.

“She had a good man,” people said. “Why did she let this one go?”

She asked herself the same question. The answer was not simple. He was not perfect. They had real incompatibilities. They had communication failures. He got tired and sometimes went quiet when she needed him to speak. But under all of that, another truth hummed: He arrived when she was closer to healing than ever before.

She had just not yet learned how to stop making pain the entry fee for love.

What This Marriage Left Her

Michael’s absence hurt differently. Not like Elias. Not like the Controllers or Punishers. Not like Daniel, whose loss had first revealed her definitions were broken. This one hurt because it showed her what she had been capable of and what she had refused. For a long time, she tried to turn him into a lesson.

“See? Good men leave too.” “See? Even when you try, it fails.” “See? I am the common denominator. Maybe I should stop.”

But another voice, stubborn and small, grew louder with time. It said: He did not almost save you. He almost became the first man you did not have to lose to feel free. You chose otherwise.

Not because you wanted pain. Because the ghost in you had not yet been fully buried. The Marriage That Almost Saved Her was not about Michael’s greatness. It was about the closeness of her awakening. About how near she came to choosing a love that did not feel like a wound.

It left her with a different kind of scar. One that did not just say, Men hurt me. One that also said, I hurt us.

That knowledge did not destroy her. It humbled her. And humility, as she would learn much later, is sometimes the last door between a life and the freedom to finally stay.

Chapter 10

When Elias Returned

Elias came back like an answer. But Diana had finally learned to ask better questions. It started with a message. Not poetic. Not dramatic. Just:

“Hey. Been a long time. I heard about... everything. How are you?”

Her body reacted before her wisdom did. Heart stutter. Stomach drop. That old, unwelcome electricity. For a moment, she was twenty□something again, standing in a doorway, hearing his voice like a song she had promised God she would stop playing. Then she remembered who she was now. A woman with therapist’s words inked in her journal. A woman who had watched a good man leave because she couldn’t stop feeding ghosts. A woman who had finally named what Elias had been:

first, yes. foundational, yes. holy, no. She put the phone down. Didn’t respond for three days. Not as a game. As a test—for herself.

“Can I let a message from him exist without making it a prophecy?”

On the fourth day, she replied.

“Hi. I’m... alive. A lot has happened. What made you reach out?”

He said he’d been thinking. About the past. About the way things ended. About the fact that he’d heard she’d been through “a lot.” He didn’t say it, but she could feel it between the lines: He still believed their story had been special. He suggested coffee. The encounter

They met in a place that felt almost too small for the size he once had in her life. A café. Light wood tables. Overpriced pastries. No dim lighting. No late-night drama. Seeing him again was like seeing an old photograph step out of its frame. Same eyes. Same smile. Same way of leaning back like the chair belonged to him more than anyone else. Age had touched him too.

Lines near his mouth. A certain heaviness in his shoulders. A quieter way of scanning the room.

“Diana,” he said, and her name in his voice still did something.

Her body remembered first. The urge to sit nearer. The instinct to laugh at jokes before they finished. The pull toward the familiar orbit. Her wisdom arrived second. She noticed things she would not have seen before. The way he asked about her in broad strokes, but filled in his own details.

“So, how many times have you been married now?” he asked with a half-smile, as if they were co-conspirators in a story only they understood.

She felt the old shame flare and then... ease.

“I’m not counting for you,” she replied softly. “Not anymore.”

He laughed.

“That’s the Diana I remember,” he said.

But it wasn’t. The Diana he remembered would have turned that into a performance. Self-deprecating joke. Innuendo. Story. This Diana let the sentence sit like a boundary. The myth he tried to reclaim Elias slipped quickly into the myth they’d once shared.

“Nothing ever felt like us,” he said. “You know that.”

There it was. The old altar. He talked about the fights like they were evidence of depth. He talked about their breakups like they were plot twists in a film people would still be talking about.

“Maybe we were just young,” he offered. “Maybe we needed time. Maybe now...”

He let the sentence hang. Maybe now we can finally get it right. Ten years ago, she would have grabbed that “maybe” with both hands. She would have seen his return as confirmation that all her marriages had been a detour back to destiny. Now, she listened.

Really listened. To the way he skipped over specific harms. To the way he framed his leaving as “freaking out.” To the way he romanticised their chaos but never once said,

“I was wrong. I was selfish. I hurt you.”

He still had charm. He still knew how to tilt his head when she spoke, making her feel like the only person in the room. He still knew how to thread sentences with nostalgia.

“Remember that night...” “Remember how we...” “Remember when you said...”

Nostalgia is a poor archivist. It keeps the highlights. Cuts the scenes that don’t test well with the heart. She remembered too. But this time, the memories didn’t play with the same soundtrack. Seeing clearly As he spoke, Diana noticed something she had never allowed herself to see:

Elias was not larger than life. He was just larger than what her life had been at the time. She had met him before she knew her own voice, before she understood her own patterns, before she realised that intensity without responsibility is just expensive immaturity. Now, sitting across from him, she could see the boy behind the myth. A boy who had loved, yes. But also a boy who had enjoyed the power of being someone’s first everything.

“Do you ever think we should have ended up together?” he asked.

He said it gently. Not as a demand. As a fantasy. Once, that question would have undone her. Now, it made her sad. Not because

she wanted to say yes. Because she realised how long she had lived as if the answer were automatically “of course.” She took a breath.

“I think,” she said slowly, “that we did exactly what we were capable of back then.”

He frowned slightly.

“That’s not very romantic.”

“It’s not meant to be.”

She watched his face as her words landed. For the first time, she saw a flicker of something that wasn’t charm. Maybe disappointment. Maybe ego bruised. Maybe the realisation that the altar he’d enjoyed existing on was finally being dismantled. Who she really missed As they talked, she noticed a dissonance. The man in front of her did not fully match the man she had been mourning.

He was less dangerous than she remembered. Less magical. Less... inevitable. He was also less cruel than some of the men who came after. He was human. Complex. Flawed. Sincere in some moments, self□protective in others. What she had been holding onto all these years was not just him.

It was her. The her who laughed too loud at his jokes. The her who believed that being chosen by someone like him proved she was special. The her who threw herself into love without checking if it could hold her weight.

“I don’t think I’ve ever loved anyone the way I loved you,” he admitted.

She nodded.

“I believe you,” she said.

He smiled, mistaking that for an opening.

“But,” she continued, “that’s not the compliment we thought it was.”

He blinked.

“What do you mean?”

“I mean,” she said, choosing each word, “we loved in a way that almost destroyed me. And I spent years calling that proof.”

Silence. He shifted in his chair.

“You’re being dramatic,” he said lightly. “We were kids. We were... learning.”

“Exactly,” she replied. “And I turned our learning into a lifelong doctrine.”

She wasn’t angry. Not in the old way. She was... grieving. Not him. The version of herself who had needed this story to mean more than it did. The first real funeral They walked outside after coffee. The sky was doing that late□afternoon thing where it couldn’t decide between bright and dim.

He walked beside her, hands in pockets, as if the past could be casually revisited.

“So,” he said, half□smiling again, “do you think there’s any chance... for us?”

There it was. The question her younger self had built an altar around. Once, she would have heard it as redemption. As God. As destiny finally catching up. Now, she heard it as a man trying to reclaim a chapter that had already been closed by the weight of reality. She stopped walking. He turned to face her.

“Elias,” she said, and his name did not taste like worship this time, “you were my first big love. That will always be true.”

He relaxed a little.

“But,” she continued, “you were also my first big lesson in what love cannot be if I plan on surviving it.”

He opened his mouth. Closed it.

“I don’t hate you,” she said. “I don’t even regret us. I just refuse to keep calling what we had the standard.”

He looked at her like she had just spoken blasphemy.

“We were special,” he insisted.

“We were,” she agreed. “And special nearly killed me.”

She wasn’t talking about bruises. She was talking about decades of demanding every man after him burn like he did.

“I miss us,” he said quietly.

“I miss who I was back then,” she confessed. “Not because she was wiser. Because she was naïve enough to think destruction was proof.”

Tears pricked her eyes. Not for him. For her. This was the funeral. Not with caskets or black clothes. With sentences.

“I release you,” she said internally, even if she never spoke the words out loud.

She released him from being the myth. From being the template. From being the reference. Coffins can be metaphors too. This one was big enough to hold a story. The story where he was the only one who had ever truly seen her. The story where every husband after was either a consolation prize or a failed attempt to recreate “us.” She buried it there. Between one step and the next.

Not by forgetting. By re□filing.

“You’ll always be part of my history,” she said finally. “But you are not my destiny.”

He laughed, trying to shake off the weight.

“Still dramatic,” he teased.

“Still alive,” she answered. After

They hugged goodbye. It was strangely... ordinary. No stolen kiss. No dramatic “one last time.” No promise to call. Her body still buzzed for a while after. Old neural pathways lit up like old streets in a city she once called home.

But another sensation overlapped it now. Relief. Elias had returned and nothing exploded. No altar rebuilt itself. No vow unravelled. He was a man with whom she had shared a dangerous, formative, intense love. He was not the axis of her life anymore.

Walking back to her own place— not a husband’s house, not a borrowed bed— she realised something quiet and enormous: For the first time, she had seen him clearly and chosen not to make that clarity into a fantasy. Elias came back like an answer. But Diana had finally learned to ask better questions. Am I safe here? Am I honest here? Does this version of love require me to disappear?

His presence did not pass the new test. That did not make him evil. It made her different. The girl who once built an altar to the love that almost destroyed her had finally done what she’d avoided for years: She had said thank you for what it taught her, grieved what it cost her, and walked away

without needing the sky to split open to prove she was doing the right thing.

Chapter 11

The Last Dress

The last wedding dress Diana owned was not on a mannequin. It was in a box. Plain cardboard. Tape yellowing at the edges. Stored in the back of a closet she rarely opened. It had followed her through moves, through endings, through new beginnings. Not always unpacked. But always there.

“Maybe my daughter will wear it,” she once told herself, in a season when the idea of children had not yet become complicated.

“Maybe I’ll sell it,” she said later, when money was tight and sentiment felt like a luxury.

She never did either. Instead, the box sat. Silent. Heavy in a way that had nothing to do with fabric. One day— not a special day, not an anniversary, just an ordinary afternoon where the air felt thick with unfinished things— she pulled it out. No music. No audience. Just her, the box, and the life she was finally ready to stop performing. Opening the box

The tape peeled back with a sound that reminded her how long she had kept this sealed. Inside, the dress lay folded more carefully than most of her memories. White. Simple. Once chosen with such intensity it had felt like choosing a self. She lifted it out slowly. It smelled faintly of old perfume, of storage, of time.

For a moment, her mind did what minds do. It replayed. The fitting room mirror. The friend who had cried. The saleswoman who had said, “This is the one.” The way she had stood on a small platform, fabric puddled around her feet, and thought,

“Once I put this on, no one can say I’m not serious about love.”

The dress had never just been cloth. It had been argument. Proof. Apology. Performance.

“I am worth choosing,” it had shouted on her behalf.

Even when the woman inside it was not sure. What the dress had carried Holding it now, years later, she saw more clearly what she had asked this garment to do. It had held the fantasy of Elias: that one day, he would see her in it and understand what he had lost. He never did. The dress outlived that fantasy. It had held the fantasy of the perfect husband: a figure who would look at her in white and never disappoint, never leave, never expose her.

It had held the fantasy of being redeemed by marriage: that enough vows, enough signatures, enough photos with rings and altars and pastors could wash away the parts of her story she still wished she could edit. It had held the fantasy of proving herself through being chosen: that every “I do” spoken to her was a stamp of approval on her worth. It had held the role of “wife” as identity: not one role among many, but the role she thought might fix the emptiness she refused to name. It had held the public version of womanhood she kept trying to satisfy.

The one who was respectable. Respecting. Respectable enough that people would stop saying,

“She just can’t stay.” “She just loves love.” “She just wants attention.”

The dress had done heavy work. Too heavy. No piece of fabric should have to stand between a woman and her own sense of value. Trying it on On impulse she did not overthink, Diana held the dress against herself in the mirror. She did not fully put it on. She just lifted it to her shoulders, let the weight of it rest there.

It didn't fit the same. Her body had changed. Softened in some places. Strengthened in others. Her face had changed more. Lines at the corners of her eyes from laughter and crying she no longer hid. A different set of sorrows. A different kind of wisdom.

She saw herself as she was then and as she was now overlaid. The younger Diana in the mirror behind her eyes looked radiant, terrified, performative. The present Diana looked... steady. Not healed. Not glowing. Just present. She realised then that what the dress had once represented no longer applied.

Back then, it had been a costume for a role she hoped would save her. Now, it was cloth. Pretty cloth. Meaningful cloth. But cloth. She lowered it. Letting go of the testimonies She thought about all the times she had used her weddings as testimonies.

"How God restored." "How God sent someone." "How God gave her a second chance, a third chance, a fourth."

Some of those testimonies had been sincere. Some had been performance. She had stood on stages, literal or emotional, telling people,

"Look what God has done," while quietly hoping He would overlook the parts she hadn't yet confessed.

The dress had been part of that act. Proof for others that she was "back on track." Standing in her room now, no ring on her finger, no man in the picture, no wedding date circled on a calendar, she understood something she had never allowed herself to say:

"I don't need a dress to testify for me."

Not about worth. Not about growth. Not about love. The last dress had seen enough altars. It did not need another. Decision She did not burn it. Drama had never saved her. It had only made her stories more cinematic for people who were not the ones waking up inside them.

She also did not put it neatly back as if nothing had changed. She folded it with respect for the woman who had worn it. Then she took out her phone and messaged a friend.

“Do you know anyone who can’t afford a wedding dress but needs one?”

The friend replied quickly.

“There’s a woman at church. Young. No family support. Was going to marry in something borrowed.”

Diana hesitated. Not because she feared letting go of the fabric. Because she understood the responsibility.

“I don’t want to pass my ghosts on with the gown,” she joked to herself.

But ghosts don’t travel in cloth. They travel in secrets. She wrote a note. Folded it. Placed it on top of the dress before closing the box. It said:

“This dress has seen a woman try to prove her worth. I pray it will see you remember yours.

Cloth cannot save us. But you deserve to feel beautiful without thinking that beauty is a bargain. Wear it if you like. Alter it if you need. Know that your value does not hang on how white the fabric is or how many vows you’ve made.

— Diana”

She smiled, half sad, half relieved. Then she sealed the box. Not with the desperation of someone trying to forget, but with the calm of someone finally ready to reassign meaning. Death of performance. That night, she stood before the mirror in ordinary clothes. No lace. No veil. No staged vulnerability.

Just a woman in a simple shirt, bare face, bare hands. She spoke quietly to her reflection.

“I am not more valuable in white.”

“I am not more forgiven because a man says ‘I do.’”

“I am not more whole because I am called ‘wife.’”

She thought of all the times she had walked into rooms trying to be the public version of womanhood: modest but not invisible, strong but not intimidating, submissive but not spineless, desired but not dangerous. Performances layered over performances. The last dress had simply been the most expensive costume. The death of performance was not loud.

It was a series of small refusals: Refusing to overshare just to seem “relatable.” Refusing to post every milestone as proof she was “okay now.” Refusing to entertain men who loved her image more than her honesty. Refusing to walk into another church and use the word “restored” as a way to avoid saying “still learning.” The last dress wasn’t just the last wedding gown. It was the last time she planned to wrap herself in an identity that depended on being chosen. After the dress

Later, sitting on her couch with nothing significant happening, she felt something unexpected. Not loneliness. Not elation. Lightness. As if some weight she had been carrying for years had finally moved one inch. Enough to notice. Not enough to break her back if it ever returned.

She touched her collarbone, where necklaces had once rested on days she wanted to look like a bride. Tonight, there was nothing there. She didn’t feel unfinished. She felt... in progress. The last dress had gone to another woman. The performance was still dying in layers.

But something had shifted. For the first time, she could imagine a future where marriage, if it ever came again, would be a chapter, not a costume. Where the word “wife” would be a role, not a replacement for “self.” Where the love she received would not need a white dress

to convince her it was real.

The last dress had done its job. Not when she wore it. When she let it go.

Chapter 12

The Woman Without a Ring

People noticed before she did that her hands were empty. Not everyone said something. Some just let their eyes drop, linger on the place where a ring used to live, and then climb back up with a new kind of caution. Others asked.

“So... what’s your situation now?” “Anyone special?” “Are you seeing someone?”

They tried to sound casual. Curious, not intrusive. Curiosity has a way of dressing itself up as concern. In the past, questions like that would have sent her into performance mode. Laugh it off. Make a joke. Offer a half-truth that made her sound either heroic or repentant.

“I’m focusing on myself.” “Me and God are working things out.” “I’m just healing right now.”

All of those sentences had been shields. This time, she tried something smaller. Sometimes she said,

“I’m single.”

Sometimes she said,

“It’s just me at the moment.”

Sometimes she just smiled and answered,

“I’m okay.”

And for the first time, okay did not feel like failure.

Ordinary Days

Life without a ring did not come with a soundtrack. It came with groceries. Standing in line at the supermarket behind a couple arguing softly about brands, she caught her own reflection in the freezer door. No ring. No husband's name attached to the life she was paying for.

Years ago, that sight would have burned. Now, it just was. She bought food for one person with room for guests, instead of for a household she was trying to prove she could manage. She went home to an apartment that was fully hers.

The bills had her name only. The mess too. So did the calm. She learned the weight of her own keys without associating them with doors she might have to slam later. Sundays changed slowly.

Church without a husband beside her had once felt like a spotlight. Usher glances. Pity smiles. Sermons that seemed to lean a little too heavily on restoration. Now, she sat where she wanted. Left when she needed. Stopped volunteering for every ministry that promised to turn her testimony into content.

If people asked where her husband was, she stopped offering short stories.

“He’s not in my life anymore,” she would say,

gentle but final. Sometimes they pushed.

“God will send someone new.” “You’re still young.” “You’re too beautiful to be alone.”

She started hearing those phrases for what they were: reflections of other people’s fear of their own solitude. She no longer took them as prophecies.

Family and Friends

Family gatherings came with their own questions.

“A woman like you shouldn’t be by herself,” an aunt would murmur,

meaning well, meaning her own life choices felt more justified if everyone ended up paired.

“So... no one?” a cousin would ask, half-teasing.

For the first time, Diana realised she did not owe anyone a narrative arc.

“No one,” she replied once, shrugging.

“I’m learning how to be with myself first.”

The words surprised her as much as they did them. She meant them. Friends invited her to dinners, to baby showers, to couple events where she was the extra chair. She stopped staying home to avoid the awkwardness. She went.

Sometimes she left early. Sometimes she stayed until the music was low and the conversations deepened. When someone inevitably asked,

“Do you miss being married?”

she no longer reached for the easy answer.

“I miss parts of it,” she said. “I don’t miss the parts where I disappeared.”

That distinction was new.

Silence

Evenings alone were the real test. No husband breathing beside her. No argument waiting at the door. No exit plan sitting ready in her bag. Just silence. Silence that, for years, she had treated like an enemy. She learned small rituals.

Making tea. Lighting one candle, not as performance, but as company. Reading books she did not have to quote to prove she was learning. Praying short prayers that did not try to impress God.

“Help me stay,” became one of them.

Not in a marriage. In the room. In her body. In the moment. There were nights when loneliness came with sharp teeth. She did not pretend otherwise. But instead of letting it drive her back into old contacts, old patterns, old altars,

she let it sit. Loneliness, when not immediately medicated, sometimes reveals the parts of you you have never met without an audience. She started meeting them. The parts that liked going to the cinema alone. The parts that enjoyed sleeping across the whole bed.

The parts that cried without needing a scene.

No Explanation Owed

With time, Diana noticed something she never thought she would experience. The ringless hand stopped feeling like a confession. At the market. At church. At family dinners. She could exist without introduction as somebody’s wife. She could meet new people without rushing to provide a status update.

She could sit in a room full of couples and not feel like a malfunctioning piece of machinery. If someone flirted, she did not treat it as confirmation that her value was intact. If no one flirted, she did not treat it as proof that it was gone. Being a woman without a ring did not suddenly make her whole. It simply removed one more costume.

One more story she had been using to avoid the harder question: Who are you when no one is asking you to be their proof of anything? She did not have a full answer yet. But she had something she never had in any of the houses, in any of the altars, in any of the performances: space.

Space to let the answer grow. Space to make mistakes without destroying another person's life in the process. Space to breathe. The world still had opinions. Some would always believe she had failed because she was not married.

Others would praise her for choosing herself. She knew now that neither group actually knew her. Being the woman without a ring was not her final identity. It was just the first season where she finally stopped running her life by the question: Who am I to someone else?

And that, more than any vow she had ever said at an altar, was what quietly prepared her for the only promise she had never really made until now.

Closing

The Vow She Made Alone

There was no altar this time.

No aisle.

No dress.

No witnesses.

Just a woman,
a quiet room,
and a life she was finally willing
to stop leaving.

Diana had said many vows in her life.

To men.

To images.

To futures she never fully entered.

"I will love you."

"I will honour you."

"I will stay."

Some of those vows she broke.

Some of them broke her.

This one was different.

She was not promising to never leave again.

She had learned enough to know that some doors still need to be used.

She was promising something quieter:

That she would not leave herself
to stay with someone else.

She sat on the edge of her bed, hands open on her knees, and spoke softly.

Not to an audience.

Not to a man.

But to the part of her that had been waiting decades to hear her own name without accusation.

"I will not use marriage to hide from my own work again," she said.

"I will not ask a man to prove I am worthy."

"I will not call pain proof of depth."

"I will not dress up self-betrayal and call it covenant."

She paused.

This was not about perfection.

It was about direction.

"I will ask better questions," she continued.

"Does this love make me smaller
or more honest?"

"Does this home feel like shelter
or stage?"

"Am I staying out of faith
or out of fear?"

"Am I leaving because I see clearly,
or because I do not yet know
how to stand still
when someone sees me?"

She did not expect heaven to answer audibly.

She just needed to hear her own voice commit to something that
did not require another person's yes to be real.

"God," she whispered,
for the first time in a long time
without handing Him a plan,

"I don't know what my life will look like
without the script of wife
as my main role."

"I just know
I don't want to keep abandoning
the woman You actually gave me to be."

The room stayed quiet.

No thunder.
No vision.

Just a slow, strange sense that this vow would not be measured
in days without mistakes, but in choices.

Choice after choice
to stay present
in her own life.

To feel the discomfort of peace
without sabotaging it.

To notice attraction to chaos
without calling it destiny.

To tell the truth sooner
instead of waiting
until the house was already on fire.

She stood.

Walked to the mirror one last time.

Not to judge.

To witness.

"You have been bride,"
she told her reflection.

"You have been ex-wife.
You have been rumour.
You have been lesson."

"This time," she said,
"be person."

No audience clapped.

No choir sang.

But something in her,
small and stubborn
and still alive,

answered.

Diana did not run this time.

She stayed.

Not with a man.

With herself.

About the Author

Sabino Pereira writes literary, confessional fiction about faith, desire, shame, survival, and the emotional cost of becoming honest. His *Bad Girl Gospel* series gives voice to women the world has judged too quickly, creating intimate fictional confessions about the stories hidden behind reputation.

About the Author

Sabino Pereira creates fiction, reflective books, music, and work about behavior, healing, discernment, faith, and modern life.

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